point. My priority is bringing peace back to the state.

Q. Then why did you say you wanted to resign on June 30?
I'm used to criticism by the Kuki people. But when some Meitei people started insulting me, I felt deeply hurt. I'm fine if outsiders and illegal immigrants do not want me to continue. But these were my own people....

Q. What is your problem with the Kukis?
We are all united, the Kukis are my own people, I don't have any problem with them. My government wants to cull out the illegal immigrants who are involved in drug trafficking and terrorism. The fact that the illegal immigrants belong to the Kuki community doesn't make all Kukis bad.

Q. A Kuki BJP MLA has alleged state complicity in the violence.
He can say whatever he wants. A probe is on. The truth will come out.

Q. There are allegations that the government aided the looting of arms from the police armoury.
This is a lie. The police tried their best, but the crowd outnumbered them. We will recover the arms.

Q. There are allegations that you are backing Meitei vigilante groups, such as the Meira Paibi, Arambai Tenggol and Meitei Leepun, that may be involved in the violence.
A lot of false propaganda is floating in the state. Due to some misunderstandings with the armed forces, the women of the Meira Paibi had blocked roads. Not any more. The Arambai Tenggol and Meitei Leepun are not armed organisations. If any evidence of their participation in the violence is found, action will be taken. We have already filed several FIRs, but we should be careful about false narratives. Recently, it was alleged that a Naga girl had been killed by the Arambai. It was a fake case.

Q. The viral video of two girls being paraded naked has shaken the nation. Have you examined the extent of sex crimes during the ethnic clashes? How do you plan to get justice for the victims?
There has been only one incident of rape mentioned in the 6,068 FIRs filed so far. I'll certainly reach out to the victims and ensure that their future is taken care of.

Q. The Meitei and Kuki now stand geographically divided. Thousands have been left homeless. What are you doing to ensure that they can go back to their homes safely?
Such clashes have happened in the past too—between Nagas and Kukis and Kukis and Paites—and both sides have forgiven and forgotten the incidents. There is no reason why reconciliation cannot happen this time too. After all, all the communities—excluding the illegal immigrants—have to live together in the state. ■

"TWO BROTHERS ARE FIGHTING, AND THE GOVERNMENT IS LIKE A FATHER MEDIATING BETWEEN THEM. WE HAVE TO BE PATIENT"

to Haokip's affidavit, he was forced to issue an official denial a week later after several BJP MLAs, including Biren's son-in-law R.K. Imo Singh, submitted a memorandum to the Union government demanding a clarification from him on the issue. The damage, however, was done, as the Union government was accused of dithering on revoking the SoO agreement with Kuki militant groups given their past political support.

BLUNDER 4: THE CENTRE'S DELAYED ACTION

If the state government stands accused of intelligence failure and ethnic bias, the Union government, which has been monitoring the law and order situation in the state, has shown no urgency to fix it. Most experts agree that had President's rule been imposed in the initial days and the armed forces given a free hand, the situation could have been remedied. The Assam Rifles reports directly to the home ministry and must have alerted it about the simmering tensions in the state. It took home minister Shah nearly a month to visit the state after it started to boil. And even though he spent three nights in Manipur, he offered nothing concrete. Peace committees were formed, but representatives from both sides stayed away.

Equally puzzling has been Prime Minister Modi's silence even as the violence spun out of control—he finally chose to speak only after the viral video sparked widespread outrage and opprobrium. Especially because he enjoys quite some cachet and popularity in the Northeast due to his focus on its development: he has made 54 trips to its eight states and made it mandatory that at least one of his ministerial colleagues visit the area once every 14 days and spend a night. Several experts from the region say people expected the PM to visit the violence-hit state and offer a healing touch. "Prime Minister Modi's silence on the Manipur violence was deeply troubling and it really hurt," says JNU professor Angomcha Bimol Akoijam, who is from Manipur.

A few Kuki civil society organisations also perceive a Hindutva bias in the actions of the state and central governments. The party leadership dismisses such assertions, but some do